in Afghanistan meant fighting there provided an opportunity to wage jihad against the Hindus and the Crusaders.

Lashkar's entrance into the Afghan front was the result of a policy decision taken by the senior leadership to launch a jihad there, after which a commander was designated to oversee operations. It is difficult to quantify how many people Lashkar deployed or recruited to fight in Afghanistan. Estimates suggest the number remained small through 2009–2010, when the group's footprint there appears to have expanded.[79] Although it was no secret that its militants were participating in the insurgency, for the purposes of deniability they did not fight openly under the Lashkar banner and nor did the group publicize their activities as prolifically as it did for those fighting in Kashmir. Instead, many fought with Lashkar-linked groups based in Kunar province or the Tribal Areas. Several interlocutors believe that Hafiz Saeed used his connections to help facilitate this development, setting up a logistical line that directed financial support and fighters to like-minded outfits.[80] In addition to those members Lashkar deployed to Afghanistan or recruited specifically to fight there, some within the organization continued to take what essentially amounted to a sabbatical and to imbed on their own with other outfits. For example, Abdur Rehman Syed spent much of 2005 and 2006 fighting alongside the Taliban, periodically returning to Lahore and working with Lashkar.[81] Allowing members to take leave or exploiting connections with other groups to channel fighters to the Afghan front contributed to the intermingling of Lashkar members with other militants. At times, it also limited the senior leadership's command and control.

Jamiat al-Dawa al-Quran wal-Sunna [JuDQS], which supported the nascent MDI after its inception in 1986, was one of the outfits Lashkar worked with to channel fighters to the Afghan front.[82] JuDQS had a presence in Kunar province, where the majority of Lashkar fighters were active, as well as a base in the Bajaur tribal agency from which militants raided across the border. Arab fighters who either settled in Kunar following the anti-Soviet jihad, or had links to people who did, provided another connection for Lashkar militants fighting there.[83] The Shah Sahib Group in Mohmand Tribal Agency provided yet another means for members of the group to access the Afghan front. Muslim Khan [a.k.a. Khalid Shah Sahib], who had been a member of Lashkar before 9/11,